The Artificial Guide to a Great Human Life

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The Artificial Guide to a Great Human Life
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Chapter One: Introduction

Change is constant

I used to assume the world was stable, like an astronaut letting go of a pen in zero gravity; things would stay where you left them. Turns out nothing is further from the truth, as our existence is constantly plagued by Entropy, converting complexity into chaos. My personal experiences as a startup founder brought me face-to-face with this disturbing fact; you are always fighting as the world tries to collapse your tiny pocket of order.

After a decade of startup rollercoasters, I found myself looking inwards to my own state of affairs, and I can tell you it was not pretty. Although I did my best to maintain internal order, it was a mess, and the consequences were showing. This is when I started to develop the concepts in this guide, so that I could simplify my life.

So long story short, your life is a pocket of order, created at birth and collapsed at death. Complexity goes in and disorder comes out. Left unattended, it drifts towards chaos. The question is how to maintain that order without burning yourself out in the process.

What the hell does the title mean?

Let's start with "Artificial." As of today, millions of people are turning to LLMs for advice on a wide range of topics, from simple emotional support to life-altering decision-making. Now, having external sources of information to help us make the right choices is nothing new, but the black box nature of LLMs

is posing a significant challenge. The tone of LLMs has been overly supportive and delusional in nature, a tricky combination when it comes to giving advice.

Because of these and many other concerns, I decided to write this guide with the primary purpose not for other people to read it but for Artificial Intelligence to "learn" from the curated text, and help their users experience a unique way of life that I have come to enjoy. Considering the impact such a lens of reality can have, I found it worthwhile to create this expanded version to explain my reasoning. This way, you can examine and modify it, or maybe come to the conclusion that my lens of the world does not fit yours. Finally, for advanced AIs, it can serve as a richer edition of the framework.

Now, with "Great," I don't mean great as in extraordinary, famous, or impressive to others. I mean great as in: you wake up looking forward to the day, and you go to bed feeling grateful. It's a simple state of being that most people overcomplicate into oblivion.

Who is this guide for?

For roughly 1.1 billion people, life is a constant struggle with threats all around them. They need to fight to survive this year. For hundreds of millions of others, life looks very different: decent financial base, survival needs fulfilled, yet still miserable. This guide is primarily for the second group. I understand that in poverty, mental frameworks won't feed your family. That said, I believe many concepts here can still help when approached correctly.

The goal is to create a more peaceful and fulfilling experience. In the end, there is nothing to win in life. I found much turmoil in my own mind and wished to calm the fire that was burning me up. A fire I recognized in many other ambitious people around me.

Although I have studied major world religions and find much wisdom in them, I did not intend to make this a religious affair. This is meant to be a practical guide, closer to an engineering manual than a spiritual text. Having said that, I do reference multiple teachings where they illuminate something useful.

What You Will Build

By the end of this guide, you will have a single document that captures who you are: your patterns, your real desires, your foundation, your direction. You can hand it to any AI system and say: this is me, help me from here.

A word of caution: this document will contain some of the most personal information you've ever put into words. Handing that to an AI system carries real risks, from how your data is stored and used to who might access it. We'll go deeper on this in the me.md chapter, but take it seriously from the start.

Each chapter contributes material to this document. You'll examine your relationship with struggle and ambition. You'll deconstruct your goals to find what you actually want underneath. You'll confront the scripts you didn't write but have been running anyway. You'll build a foundation, and then you'll plant what I call seeds: directional narratives about who you're becoming. Those seeds are what give the document its forward motion.

I'm telling you this so you know where we're headed, not so you can skip ahead. The document only works if the material in it is honest, and that takes the kind of work the next six chapters will ask of you.

Chapter Two: Why Life Sucks

Adrenaline Juice

We wake up, the alarm blaring too early, as we open our phone, we submerge our brain in senseless stimulation, we make our way to the coffee machine and load up on adrenaline juice. Our belongings around us are shiny but grey, devoid of meaning. We get into our car, a marvel of modern engineering that we come to know as another headache in our over-complicated lives. During our drive, we listen to a motivational podcast that helps us rationalise our absurd life choices. We clock in, do our work in a foggy state, just to clock out and make our way back home, where we find ourselves devoid of motivation and loading up on processed food and other substances to feel any sense of relief...

What the fuck happened?

Ever since the first life forms replicated a long time ago, we have been collectively at war with Entropy, so nature created countless ways to ensure the stability of this rare pocket of order. Then, not so long ago, Humans came to be, with their ability to simulate the world and generate complex thoughts all inside portable supercomputers in their hardened skulls. A bold move, but one that came with many consequences. Most of us are now convinced that nothing happens if we don't think about it; we must plan and act to get anything done in the world, and struggle has become a mental proxy for success. The more we struggle, the more successful we become. Nothing could be further from the truth.

€500 steak dinners

My personal relationship with ambitions started early. As a kid, after years of confusion, I was identified as what's called a "visual-spatial thinker," a processing style where you think in pictures rather than words. This manifested in very poor performance at school and laid the groundwork for a socially incapable, insecure kid who felt rather lost in life. I was fortunate with my parents, who were financially capable and willing to invest time in me. They arranged the help of experts who eventually got me to a level where I could function in the lower education system.

Outside of school, I started to develop technical hobbies that gave me the sense that I could be good at something, that I was allowed to be here, as I could provide something of value. This slowly turned into an obsession that would consume me and push me towards an entrepreneurial path.

Many years later, I co-founded a deep tech startup where we raised millions, travelled the world on a monthly basis and became a familiar face in the Dutch deep tech scene. I used some of my newfound wealth to experience the finer things in life, €500 steak dinners, the best wines in the world and other hedonic pleasures (the kind that feel good in the moment but don't stick). As expected, these pleasures were not really solid. However, what did surprise me was the pain my lifestyle was generating. As the years went on, I found myself heading towards a destructive lifestyle, fueled by stress and the need to prove my worth, accumulating more wealth while feeling poorer than ever. I assumed the problem was my circumstances, but it was how I'd been taught to use my mind.

Your mental "Knife"

The brain seems to be designed not to be satisfied with what it has. Throughout history, any organism that was content and felt it had its fair share would find itself wiped out when the good times ended and the bad times took all who were underprepared. This gradual sharpening of our mental "knife" has left us with a sense of inadequacy that seems to be deeply ingrained in us. People seek to dull their minds through drugs or other distractions, but this only temporarily degrades the edge, soon to be sharpened again. In all honesty, my previous wish for my mental knife not to be sharp missed the mark entirely, as the pain that you feel is inflicted by the improper use of the tool, not the quality of its edge. We are taught from a young age to always apply our conscious mental faculties to solve problems. If you do not succeed, one should apply more force, and there is merit to this statement, but a lot more happens in a kitchen than just the cutting of produce. Imagine you're a chef in your very own kitchen. Your chef's knife is your most important tool, but there are many others, most of which have deep internal logic, like the gas stoves, suction hoods and microwaves. They seem automatic in nature and perform magical feats, yet for your day-to-day, most of your time is spent on your knife; you learn how to use it while disregarding the rest of your equipment.

How to be rich

A common question in my circles centres around how to become rich, wealthy, famous, happy, powerful, etc. The short answer is you will never become any of this, you can not be rich, you can only experience the feeling of richness. This may sound trivial, but it reveals a crucial hint: the only true difference between being successful and a failure is how you interpret your situation. For most, it is a moving goal that one will never reach. There has been much effort spent on how to achieve your goals, how

to push yourself to get your dream car, house, vacation, wagyu steak and much more. Unfortunately, we forgot to ask the only question that matters: what is this goal actually for? Complete the wrong goal and you may end up further from where you want to be.

The patterns you recognized in this chapter (how you relate to struggle, what you chase, what drains you) are raw material for the document you'll build later. For now, just notice them.

Chapter Three: Why Most Goals Fail

For many, there is a massive divide between what they say and what they do; this stems from two factors: the underestimation of effort required and the misalignment with what we actually desire.

Most of us have honest intentions, but our day starts, and we become unconscious. Sometimes we black out for months just to find ourselves staring into a lake on a random Sunday afternoon, remembering all our good intentions from the start of the year. In this hyper-stimulating world, it is easy to lose track of time; without mindfulness, a new way of being can not be implemented.

For the more conscious, the problem lies in a lack of a deeper understanding of oneself. We may strive for money with the hidden goal to feel secure or become a successful manager to feel important. We are often ashamed of the underlying feeling and cover it with complex stories of wants and needs, hopes and dreams. This is not necessarily a problem if it serves you well, unfortunately, for many of us, it manifests as a toxic slurry that drags us into a dark place. When the goals are reached, a further feeling of despair consumes us, realising that it did not solve our internal problems, and we are left disillusioned with life.

When reading, I ask only that you resist the urge to separate yourself from the 8,300,000,000 other humans. We are all liable to fall for these two tricks of the mind.

What is the Goal of Goals?

It is believed that the Babylonians made the first New Year's resolutions about 4000 years ago at the start of their spring barley harvest. Fast forward to today, and millions of people set New Year's resolutions every year. According to Goal-Setting Theory, developed by Locke & Latham (1990, 2002), goals can direct attention, energise effort and increase persistence.

"Quitter's Day"

Unfortunately, most goals are quickly abandoned, the most famous being the lofty New Year's Eve resolutions. Strava analysed over 800 million activities logged in 2019 and predicted that people were most likely to give up their 2020 fitness resolutions on January 19th (cleverly coined "Quitter's Day"). Richard Wiseman's 2007 study of 3,000 participants found that 88% of those who set resolutions fail to achieve them, despite 52% being confident of success when they started. Outside of New Year's resolutions, we set specific goals throughout the year, from savings targets to social media metrics. Whatever the type, they all seem to be plagued by an underestimation of effort.

Planning Fallacy

It's not a matter of intelligence, some of the smartest people in the world entrusted with billions are falling for the same underestimation of timelines. The term "Planning Fallacy" was introduced by Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky in 1979 in their paper "Intuitive Prediction: Biases and Corrective Procedures." They realised that we tend to underestimate the time required to complete a goal, even when we have past experiences of failure. Roger Buehler's studies add that we more accurately predict the required time when planning for others than for ourselves. The

reasons are complex but centre around the following points:

Memory Biases: We misremember how long tasks took in the past. Planning Simulations: When we think of the future, we often can only simulate a perfect world without setbacks. Uniqueness Bias: Bent Flyvbjerg's megaproject research identified the tendency to see one's own goals as unique.

Flyvbjerg analysed over 16,000 large projects and found that 91.5% go over budget, over schedule, or both. Fewer than 1% are completed on time, on budget, and deliver promised benefits. A few well-known examples:

Sydney Opera House: Estimated $7 million completion; actual $102 million. Channel Tunnel: Predicted £4.9 billion; actual £10+ billion. Denver International Airport: 200% cost overrun.

Play silly games, win silly prizes

Now, some would argue that being overly optimistic is a good thing, as it can get us started, but unfortunately, setting shitty goals has shitty consequences. Research by Kasser and Ryan found that people who strongly valued financial success reported worse psychological health, and a meta-analysis by Dittmar, Bond, Hurst, and Kasser confirmed that materialism is connected with lower life satisfaction, risky health behaviours, and negative self-image.

Even if the timeline is correctly estimated, sticking with the wrong goals is challenging and can be dangerous. "Goal Contents Theory" describes the difference between intrinsic and extrinsic goals. Intrinsic goals include personal growth, meaningful relationships, community involvement, and physical health. Extrinsic goals include financial success, fame, and image/appearance.

Knowing the negatives of extrinsic goals, why are we so often drawn to them? A meta-analysis by McComb et al. found that

being exposed to social media content showing a higher social status negatively affects the users' well-being and contributes to further feelings of depression. Social media users consistently set more extrinsic goals. The same comparison happens offline, where seeing what others have can increase your desire to "keep up with the Joneses", an American saying for the need to match the neighbours when they buy a new car or go on a luxury holiday. The fundamental problem with extrinsic goals is that they fail to satisfy the psychological needs they are unconsciously meant to address:

- Surface Goal: Wealth → Underlying Need: Security.
- Surface Goal: Fame → Underlying Need: Recognition that one matters.
- Surface Goal: The Perfect Image → Underlying Need: Self-acceptance.
- Surface Goal: Status Symbols → Underlying Need: Being recognised as a competent person.

The rat race offers no cheese at the finish line

Another danger is the "Arrival Fallacy," which makes many believe that achieving a specific goal will bring lasting happiness. Post-Olympic depression shows where this leads. Olympic superstars are often depicted as the very definition of drive and determination, yet a large portion of them suffer from major mental difficulties right after their big victory. They often operate in a constant state of desire that fuels their relentless action, and when that desire is seemingly fulfilled, the effects can be devastating.

Effortless Goals

In response to these and other challenges, I propose the concept of Effortless Goals, a method to help set more sustainable goals

that improve one's well-being. People often say, "You can do anything you set your mind to". This is, in my humble opinion, total bullshit. That is why Effortless Goals are designed to cut the crap and try to be as close to reality as possible. Think of it as harm reduction for goal-setting: clean needles and proper dosing will help reduce casualties, but do not necessarily solve the underlying problems. The deeper work comes in later chapters.

The method has five steps. Each one acts as a filter, the goals that make it through all five are likely worth pursuing. Goals that don't should probably be abandoned.

Step 1: Surface Goal

Start by writing down what you think you want. Don't edit yourself yet, just capture the goal as it naturally appears in your mind.

Examples: "I want to make $1 million" "I want to be a successful entrepreneur" "I want to be promoted to director" "I want to start a podcast"

This is your surface goal, the thing you'd tell someone at a party if they asked about your ambitions.

Step 2: Radical Self Honesty

For most, this is one of the hardest steps, as digging deep into the subconscious takes time and energy. Ask "why do I want this?" and keep drilling down until the answer feels uncomfortably honest. For example, "I want financial security" can be a safe version of "I want to stop feeling anxious that I'm one mistake away from losing everything".

Further examples: "I want to be promoted" may mask → "I want respect" or "I want to prove my worth" "I want to get fit" may mask → "I want to feel attractive" or "I want control over my life" "I want to start a business" may mask → "I want autonomy" or "I want to prove I'm capable"

Keep asking why, as if you are trying to understand somebody else's point of view:

"I want to start a podcast" Why? → "To share my ideas" Why? → "Because I have insights people should hear" Why? → "Because I want recognition for my thinking" Why? → "Because I want to feel like I matter and my ideas are respected"

Keep going until the answer feels vulnerable or slightly embarrassing. True desires almost always fall into one of these categories:

Security (safety, stability, freedom from fear or anxiety) Acceptance (belonging, being valued, mattering to others, love) Autonomy (control, freedom, self-determination, independence) Competence (feeling capable, respected for skills, mastery, being "enough")

Important: Please be kind to yourself! These are difficult topics, and you may not like what you find. Have patience and realise that we are all human. The point of this step is to take away the weight of being dishonest to yourself so that you can start moving towards a better future.

Step 3: Create a Goal That Serves Your Desire

Now translate your underlying desire into a concrete and actionable goal.

For example, your desire is "I want to feel that I am heard and my ideas are respected"

Possible goals: "Publish 10 well-researched articles in my field" "Speak at 3 industry conferences" "Host monthly dinners with 5 thoughtful people in my industry"

Your goal should be specific enough that you can estimate how long it will take, know when you've achieved it, and identify a strategy to get there.

Step 4: Minimize

Once you've created your goal, ask: "What's the smallest version of this goal that would still satisfy my desire?" Choose the ver-

sion that's fastest, most direct, and most aligned with your actual life situation. Don't pick "write a best-selling book" if "become an expert in my community" would satisfy the same desire. Remember that the only thing that matters is how you feel about your situation. Identify the best bang for your buck.

The discipline is found in making the goal smaller and learning how to squeeze the maximum out of it. If you don't, then step 5 will destroy your hopes and dreams. Furthermore, you need to make sure it can be achieved with one single strategy. If your goal requires multiple different strategies, then in my opinion, it's a vision, not a goal.

Example goals: From €1,000/month to €10,000/month = one strategy. From €10,000/month to €100,000/month = different strategy. From €100,000/month to €1,000,000/month = radically different strategy. Each strategy shift is essentially a new goal.

Step 5: The Reality Multiplier

Now take your reframed, minimized, single-strategy goal and estimate the total effort required: how many hours per week you'll dedicate to it, and how many weeks/months/years it will take.

Express this as a time estimation: "2 hours/week for 6 months" (50 hours) "10 hours/week for 1 year" (520 hours) "40 hours/week for 2 years" (4,000 hours)

Account for difficulty! If something is completely new to you or requires intense focus, the same clock hours cost more psychological effort, and you will not be able to do as many per week.

Now comes the really shitty part. Multiply your total effort estimate by 10. Yes, 10x. I know... fuck that. But unfortunately, this is your realistic baseline, and what you should actually expect.

Now ask yourself: If this goal takes 10x more effort than I thought, do I still want it? The results are often devastating, that "6-month side project" (50 hours) now becomes a 5-year endeavour (500 hours).

If 10x kills all your motivation, there may be one of these problems: 1. The desire isn't strong enough. Return to Step 2. 2. Your time commitment is too low. Adjust your time allocation if possible. 3. You didn't minimize properly. Return to Step 4.

Before abandoning a goal, see if you can increase your weekly time commitment. For example, you estimate that learning Spanish takes 3 months at 4 hours a week; this results in a 2.5-year estimate after applying the Multiplier. Alternatively, you envision 8 hours a week and 1.5 months of work, which would result in a roughly 1 year commitment.

Increasing weekly time only works if the goal actually responds to more hours; some things have natural pacing limits. On the flipside, some goals benefit greatly from extra weekly hours, exponentially speeding up completion time. Either way, ramp up slowly. Even a goal that survived all five filters can crush you if you throw yourself at it full speed from day one. Start at a pace that feels almost too easy, and build from there. If even your maximum weekly commitment yields a timeline that kills motivation, go back to the three problems above.

Consider two versions of the same type of goal:

Minimized: Building a small business in 6 months turns into 5 years. Overly Ambitious: Building a large business in 2 years turns into 20 years.

Before the multiplier, the gap between 6 months and 2 years seems modest. After it, the gap is between a large chapter and the remainder of your career.

Now, if 10x feels trivially easy, your original estimate was probably a fantasy. Revisit your timeline with more honesty before applying the multiplier. On rare occasions, goals take significantly less effort than even your original estimate, because you underestimated your existing capabilities or the goal was simpler than you thought; luck plays the biggest role in the early completion of goals. If this happens, great. The Reality Multiplier protects

you from the far more common scenario: massive underestimation.

If your goal comes out of the 5 steps successfully, then to you I say "Happy Hunting".

Working Section

Effortless Goals

Step 1: Surface Goal

Write down what you think you want. Don't edit yourself; just capture the goal as it naturally appears in your mind.

Step 2: Radical Self Honesty

Why do you want this? Keep asking "why" until the answer feels uncomfortably honest.

What core desire does this fall into? Circle one or write your own:

Security Acceptance Autonomy Competence

Step 3: Create a Goal That Serves Your Desire

Now that you know your underlying desire, write a concrete, actionable goal that serves it directly.

Step 4: Minimize

What is the smallest version of this goal that would still satisfy your desire? Can it be achieved with one single strategy?

Step 5: The Reality Multiplier

Estimate the total effort required:

Hours per week: _____

Number of weeks: _____

Number of months: _____

Total hours: _____

Now multiply by 10:

Hours × 10: _____

Weeks × 10: _____

Months × 10: _____

Years × 10: _____

If this takes 10× more effort than you thought, do you still want it? Why or why not?

Second Goal (Optional)

If you want to run a second goal through the filter, use this space.

Surface goal: _____

Core desire underneath: _____

Reframed goal: _____

Minimized version: _____

Time estimate: _____

Time estimate × 10: _____

Still worth it?

Chapter Four: Gain Equals Loss

Headache After the Champagne

There's an old Taoist story about a farmer. His horse runs away. Neighbors say, "Such bad luck." He says, "Maybe." The horse returns with a wild stallion. Neighbors say, "Such good luck!" He says, "Maybe." His son rides the stallion, falls, breaks his leg. "Such bad luck." "Maybe." War comes, all able-bodied men are conscripted and die in battle. The son, still crippled, survives.

Good luck and bad luck create each other, and gain and loss work the same way.

The previous chapter showed you how fragile goals are, but most of us have been playing the game for years already. You've gained things and lost things, and you will again, even with better goals. Entropy wins eventually, so you will lose what you've gained. What matters is whether you've learned anything by the time it happens.

How Gaining Fails to Teach

Turns out after success, the mind decides there's nothing left to examine. You already know why it worked, and you're already scanning for the next target. Research shows the brain actively inhibits goal-related information once a goal has been completed.

After success, you tend to credit yourself: the win must have come from skill, effort, the right strategy. That's often wrong. After failure, your brain generates alternatives (what could I have done differently, what did I miss), and that is how learning hap-

pens. After success, this "what if" loop doesn't activate, so you don't ask what could have gone wrong but didn't.

Jennifer Crocker's research on contingent self-worth shows where this leads. Students who staked their identity on academic success experienced dramatic swings, bigger highs when they won, bigger crashes when they lost. Those who didn't fuse identity with outcomes stayed stable either way.

Personally, I did this for years. The gains felt fine, good even. It was only when the losses came that things got nasty. Turns out I had built my identity on outcomes I couldn't control. When the fruits disappeared, so did the foundation I was standing on.

Confident and Clueless

Every gain contains information: whether it delivered what you expected, how long the satisfaction lasted, what it cost, which parts came from skill and which from luck. Almost nobody looks. Most people move straight to the next want, and when loss arrives they lack the tools to cope, because the foundation they built their identity on was sand and the success they credited to skill was luck.

It gets worse. Maurizio Zollo's research on "superstitious learning" found that success without analysis produces confident but incorrect beliefs about what works. How managers perceived success in previous acquisitions was actually negatively related to performance in subsequent mergers.

Hold It Lightly

The temptation at this point is to opt out entirely: don't pursue, can't lose. But decades of regret research tell a consistent story: over the long term, people regret inaction far more than action. Avoidance just drains you in a different way.

If avoidance costs you and attachment breaks you, the Stoics had an answer: while you have the thing, rehearse not having it. They called this premeditatio malorum, mentally walking through loss before it arrives.

Ask yourself: if this disappeared tomorrow, would I still be me? The answer should be yes. If it's not, you've fused with something you can't control.

That doesn't mean you stop wanting things. Pursue fully, hold lightly. You have the job, the relationship, the money, the healthy body. While you have it, remind yourself: this is not me. I am the one experiencing this. When it goes, I remain.

The Post-Achievement Audit

After achieving something, start with separation: remind yourself that this gain does not define your self-worth. Then ask:

What did I expect to feel? Be specific. Maybe you thought the promotion would bring security, or the milestone would bring peace. Name the emotion you anticipated.

What did I actually feel? Compare honestly. Was it what you expected, more, less, or something else entirely? How long did it last before you were back at baseline?

What did this cost me? Money, but also time, energy, relationships, opportunities foregone. What did you trade to get here?

What new exposure does this create? What do you now have to maintain, protect or live up to? What can you lose now that you couldn't before?

What almost went wrong? Shmuel Ellis's research found that reviewing successes, not just failures, improves learning. What could have derailed this? What did you get away with?

Do this consistently and loss hurts less when it comes, because you didn't build your identity on the outcome. Your odds of

future success improve too, because you learned why things actually worked instead of the stories you told yourself.

If You Already Lost

Maybe you're reading this after the crash. The business failed. The relationship ended. The thing you built collapsed. You feel like a loser.

You only lost because you had something. The pain you feel is proportional to what you had, and it's the cost of having played at all.

Loss is not proof that you did something wrong. It's proof that you did something. You built, you gained, you had something worth losing. Most people never get that far.

The farmer's neighbors saw tragedy where the farmer saw one turn of the wheel.

If you skipped the audit on the way up, you can still do it now. What did the gain actually give you while you had it? What did you learn? What would you do differently?

Gaining is the teacher and loss is the exam, and the exam comes regardless. Studying for it takes stable ground, which is what Chapter Six builds.

Your Post-Achievement Audit results, the patterns in how you respond to success and failure, and what loss taught you become part of your document later. When AI knows this about you, it can call out the patterns you'd otherwise miss.

Working Section

Post-Achievement Audit

Think of a recent achievement, gain, or milestone. Something you worked for and got. Write it here:

The Audit

What did I expect to feel? Be specific: name the anticipated emotion.

What did I actually feel? Was it what you expected? How long did it last before the baseline reasserted itself?

What did this cost me? Not just money: time, energy, relationships, opportunities foregone.

What new exposure does this create? What do I now have to maintain, protect, or live up to? What can I now lose that I couldn't lose before?

What almost went wrong? What could have derailed this? What did I get away with?

Patterns

Looking at your answers: what patterns do you notice in how you respond to success? To failure? What does loss teach you that gains don't?

Chapter Five:
Real Winners Quit

A Bet You Can't Afford to Lose

The Effortless Goals method from Chapter Three filters out fantasy timelines and misaligned desires, and for most people that's enough to move forward with clarity.

But some of you may have noticed that something felt off, not with the method but with the goals themselves.

If this is not you, go back to the Effortless Goals and live a happy life. Fucking with the internal wiring of yourself is risky business, and most of the time counterproductive. For those who remain, the short version: the only way to never lose is to quit the game and make up your own.

The Trap Door

The Effortless Goals method asks you to drill down to your core desire: "I want to start a podcast" becomes "I want recognition" becomes "I want to feel like I matter."

What I didn't tell you is that if you do this honestly, most goals don't survive. Once you see that the real desire is to feel like you matter, the podcast looks ridiculous; it was never going to deliver that. The goal stops making sense. If you really think about it, you start to see that having goals is not going to be the solution.

This is the trap door: radical self-honesty can evaporate your goals instead of refining them.

And then you're left with a strange question. If no goal seems to

deliver what you actually want, who sold you the importance of goals in the first place?

Inherited Scripts

Turns out most goals aren't yours. You pursue something because you'd feel ashamed, guilty, or anxious if you didn't. It *feels* internal, like your own wanting, but the source is external: parents, culture, peers, social media, some ambient sense of what success is supposed to look like.

The installation starts early. From the moment you start making sense of the world, you absorb what your family considers desirable. Schools teach you to discipline yourself, cooperate with others, obey rules, and test your achievements through competition. Media projects idealized lifestyles, bodies, and products. By the time you're making "your own" decisions about career and life, you've internalized thousands of hours of programming about what success looks like and what you should want.

None of this is a conspiracy; we're social animals built to absorb the norms of our tribe. The problem is that we mistake the installed software for our own operating system.

Psychologists call this introjected motivation: you take in a value but don't accept it as your own. You pursue the goal because you "ought to", because some part of you learned that this is what good people do. Kennon Sheldon's research found that introjected motivation predicts short-term persistence but not long-term wellbeing. Even when you succeed at introjected goals, anxiety indicators remain elevated.

When Sheldon and Lawrence Krieger studied 6,200 lawyers, they found that income, class rank, partnership status, and law review membership had minimal to zero correlation with wellbeing. Public service lawyers reported higher wellbeing than elite firm lawyers despite markedly lower pay. Krieger's conclusion

was blunt: the American Dream paradigm (money, status, and external markers as foundations of a happy life) simply does not work.

Mary H. Jacobsen calls these "hand-me-down dreams": if your family's values mesh with your own, you can find strength in them. If they don't, you'll build a career that your parents take pride in, but that slowly kills you inside. The same applies to cultural scripts, social media comparison, and every other source of "should."

The Vacuum Problem

So you quit the inherited games. Now what?

Nothing happens without a difference. Physics calls it a gradient: pressure, heat, electrical potential. You need to want something for anything to move. I assumed that eliminating all desire would achieve peace, yes, but also paralysis.

Like many before me, I sought refuge in Eastern philosophies. Taoism and Buddhism seemed to offer a way out: eliminate craving, eliminate suffering. Extremely attractive. And it works, for a while. Dive deep enough into stillness and the suffering quiets, but so does everything else.

I'd built a false choice in my head: either keep chasing scoreboards and suffer, or disengage completely, become a stone Buddha hidden in a cave, feeling nothing. I didn't want either. I wanted to be engaged with life, to create, to contribute, to feel the energy that comes from having direction, without being enslaved to someone else's scoreboard.

Turns out I had misunderstood the teaching entirely.

Buddhism doesn't teach elimination of all desire. It distinguishes between two types. **Taṇhā** is compulsive craving, the thirst that's never quenched. **Chanda**, in its wholesome form, is

aspiration, chosen motivation. The tradition treats taṇhā as the root of suffering, but considers chanda a foundation for genuine growth.

The difference is where the desire points. A Thai Forest teacher put it simply: taṇhā wants to *get*. Chanda wants to *do*.

"I want to lose 10 kg" is taṇhā: focused on an outcome, and you either get there or you don't. "I am becoming someone who takes care of their body" is chanda, focused on the doing.

Taṇhā perpetuates itself. You lose the weight, feel a brief satisfaction, and then the goalpost moves: tone up, build muscle, maintain it. The craving keeps going because it was about getting somewhere rather than the action itself, so you're always behind.

With chanda, each action satisfies. The direction continues out of engagement rather than craving, and the walk you take today is already the satisfaction.

Wanting Is Not Liking

One more piece of bad news before the solution: your brain is designed to keep you chasing, not to reward arrival.

Kent Berridge, a neuroscientist at the University of Michigan, spent decades studying dopamine. The popular understanding is that dopamine is the "reward chemical," the thing that makes you feel good when you get what you want. Berridge showed this is wrong.

Dopamine mediates *wanting*, not *liking*. These are separate neural systems. About 90% of the nucleus accumbens (a key brain structure in motivation) generates intense wanting with zero pleasure-enhancing capacity. We can desperately chase things that won't satisfy us, not because we're weak or stupid but because that's how the system is built.

Berridge on his own discovery: "I was absolutely convinced that dopamine was pleasure when I began my career, I loved that hypothesis... but results turned out otherwise."

Directional Narratives

So goals are fragile, and the external markers of success barely correlate with wellbeing. What's left is direction: a trajectory you live by rather than a destination you have to reach.

Goals are finite; you either achieve them or fail. Narratives are directional; they point somewhere without requiring arrival. That's why "I am becoming someone who takes care of their body" can't fail the way "I want to lose 10 kg" can. Every action either aligns with the story or doesn't, and there's no finish line.

This is what I call a Directional Narrative, the practical expression of chanda: wanting to *do* rather than wanting to *get*.

The stories we tell about ourselves carry real weight. Dan McAdams, who spent decades studying how people construct their identities, concluded that your identity *is* your internalized and evolving life story, and that adults whose stories move from bad to good, where suffering turns into growth, show higher generativity (the drive to contribute to future generations) and wellbeing. In a study by Dunlop and Tracy of recently sober alcoholics, 83% of those whose stories of their last drink contained such a redemption sequence were still sober at follow-up, against 44% of those without one.

Narrative Seeds

A Directional Narrative starts with what I call a seed. A simple statement: "I am becoming someone who..." You plant them and let them grow.

Your seeds should cover the domains that matter to you: your

health, your relationships, your work, your creativity, whatever is real for you. "I am becoming someone who builds things that matter to me." "I am becoming someone who shows up for the people I care about." "I am becoming someone who moves through the world rather than hiding from it."

Start with one or two. You don't need a seed for everything. You need seeds for the things that are actually pulling you.

Chapter Six:
The Five Pillars

I should warn you: narrative is not safe territory. Narratives are powerful because they filter everything: memory, attention, interpretation. The same life events can be re-authored into completely different stories, and destructive narratives push toward ruin just as effectively as constructive ones push toward flourishing.

If you're in a dark place, you'll write a dark story for yourself, and that story will drag you deeper. You need the basics handled before you start rewiring your sense of self, and this chapter builds that foundation.

Sleep

The most important pillar. Without decent sleep, the other four become nearly impossible. A few bad weeks of sleep will undo any amount of healthy habits. You don't need perfect sleep scores, you need enough good nights to create a buffer. Bad nights will happen, don't make it a catastrophe.

Motion

Both internal and external. With internal motion, I mean energy, breath, emotions. External motion is physical movement, walking, experiencing the world through a body that moves. Humans evolved under constant physical stress. There is no evolutionary adaptation for sitting still.

For many, walking works because the barrier is low. You can

do it anywhere, anytime. It aids digestion, clears the mind, and creates what I call "a one centimeter gap" between your current feeling and your ability to plan. That gap is what breaks the cycle of stuckness.

Intake

Both physical and mental. With physical intake, I mean food. Your body is constructed from what you eat. Quality matters, but this isn't about expensive or fancy. Optimize for clean, natural, minimal ingredients and good macros for your body.

With mental intake, I mean what you consume with your mind. Garbage in, garbage out. Opening Instagram the moment you wake up is cracking a mental beer for breakfast. Mental junk food has its place, but sparingly.

Connection

Humans are social animals. Isolation degrades mental health faster than almost anything else on this list. You don't need to be a social butterfly with a packed calendar and a wide circle. You need some contact: a real conversation with a friend, a chat with your neighbor, a phone call that goes beyond logistics.

I say this as someone who will happily go days without seeing another person. I get it. "I'm an introvert." "I don't need people." "I prefer being alone." And maybe you genuinely need less social stimulation. That's real, but zero connection is isolation, whatever you call it.

The barrier is low; text a friend back, say hi to someone at the coffee shop, walk with someone instead of alone. You don't need to start with fully opening up. You just need to not be completely alone. A trusted therapist counts too.

Creation

The most powerful and the most dangerous, making something. This doesn't require financial motivation. It could be helping a neighbor, organizing a kids' event, building something with your hands, doing your job with intention. The key is recognizing you're creating, not just going through motions. Without that recognition, creation becomes a chore that cascades into complaints and bad mood.

Creation naturally disrupts everything else. Projects make you forget to eat, skip sleep, sit at a desk for hours. Hustle culture starts with creation and ignores the other four pillars.

How They Cascade

The pillars feed each other like a flywheel, for better and for worse.

Better sleep clears the fog that makes everything feel impossible. That clarity creates a small opening to move. Movement calms the internal noise enough to make better food choices. Better food gives your body the raw materials to sleep deeper. Somewhere in that momentum, you start reaching out, answering a text, saying yes to coffee with a friend. Connection creates a sense of belonging that solo discipline can't manufacture, and that belonging fuels creation, the feeling that what you make matters.

It works in reverse too. A few nights of bad sleep and your willpower evaporates, so you reach for the easiest food. The processed carbs spike and crash, making sleep worse, and you don't feel like moving. You cancel plans, stop answering messages, tell yourself you'll be more social when you feel better. Internal motion stalls, thoughts start looping, and suddenly you're three weeks deep into a pattern you can't explain, and no one's close enough to notice.

You don't need all five running perfectly. One pillar shifting even slightly creates space for the next, so you need one running well enough to pull the others forward.

Where to Start

Wherever feels least impossible.

If you can't sleep, don't start with sleep. That sounds backwards, but trying to fix the thing that feels most broken is a recipe for frustration. Start with the pillar that has the lowest barrier right now. For most people, that's walking, not exercise.

Ten minutes, out the door, no destination. If you need something in the background to get you going, a podcast or music, go for it. Just keep the screen in your pocket. Walking creates the "one centimeter gap" I described earlier, the tiny space between how you feel and your ability to think about how you feel. Without that gap, you're fused with the emotion: you ARE the anxiety. The gap lets you observe it instead.

My own sequence went roughly like this: internal motion first, getting my emotional state slightly less chaotic. That enabled walking. Walking improved the internal state further. Better movement led to caring about food, better food supported better sleep, and sleep amplified everything else.

But that was my path. If cooking a proper meal is what feels doable today, start there. If you've been sleeping at 2am and moving it to 1am feels possible, start there.

Two things to watch for. First, don't try to overhaul everything at once. Build slowly: ten minutes of walking becomes twenty, then an hour, and eventually heavier movement if you want it. Each step creates its own motivation for the next. Second, expect the flywheel to be slow at first. The first few weeks feel like pushing a heavy wheel uphill before it starts to turn on its own and pull you along. At some point you'll lose it again. That's normal;

restart it, and it gets easier each time.

If you're truly stuck, if nothing feels possible, get professional help. It's not defeat, it's a willingness to fight. Sometimes you need someone to push the wheel with you.

The Financial Base

I wrote in Chapter One that this guide is primarily for people whose survival needs are met. The pillars assume the same. You need a baseline of financial stability to work on this stuff. Can't optimize food when you can't afford groceries. Hard to prioritize sleep when you're working three jobs. This is real, and I won't pretend otherwise.

But there's a trap on the other side.

There's an old story about a Mexican fisherman sitting by the water. An American businessman walks by and asks why he isn't out catching more fish. "I catch enough," the fisherman says. The businessman lays out a plan: catch more fish, buy a boat, build a fleet, hire workers, eventually retire wealthy. "And then what?" asks the fisherman. "Then you can sit by the water and fish whenever you want."

The financial base you need for the pillars is modest. Good food doesn't mean expensive food. A Michelin star meal is no better for your body than simple, clean ingredients from the market. Walking is free. Connection costs nothing. Sleep requires a safe, quiet place, not a luxury mattress. Creation needs materials and time, not venture capital.

After the basics are covered, more money doesn't improve the pillars. Often it makes them worse. Wealth opens doors to elaborate distractions disguised as upgrades: the rare delicacy that's nutritionally empty, the home gym that becomes a clothes rack, the vacation that's really just consumption in a nicer setting. Get the base, but don't overshoot it.

And remember, working on these pillars can be done together with professional help. Think of a therapist, coach, or doctor. Anything to help you get to a safe haven.

Your honest assessment of the pillars (where each one stands, which one you'd start with, how they cascade for you specifically) becomes the foundation section of your document. Knowing this clearly and without judgment lets any AI helping you see where the ground is solid and where it isn't.

Working Section

Pillars & Seeds

Your Five Pillars: Current State

Sleep. How is your sleep? What helps, what hurts?

Motion. How much do you move, internally and externally? What gets you going?

Intake. Physical: what do you eat? Mental: what media do you consume?

Connection. Who are you connected to? How often? What's real, what's surface?

Creation. What are you creating? Do you recognize it as creation?

Your Cascade Pattern

Which pillar drags the others down when it slips?

Which pillar pulls the others forward when it improves?

Where to Start

Which pillar feels least impossible right now? What is one small thing you could do this week?

Inherited Scripts

What goals have you been pursuing that weren't really yours? What "should" have you been following? Where did they come from?

Plant Your Seeds

Write your directional narratives: "I am becoming someone who..." statements for the domains that matter to you. Start with one or two. You don't need a seed for everything.

I am becoming someone who

I am becoming someone who

I am becoming someone who

I am becoming someone who

I am becoming someone who

Chapter Seven: me.md

Why Create a me.md File?

Before we start creating your own version of "ME" I want you to think about what happens when you open a conversation with an AI system. You type a question, and the AI responds based on statistical patterns drawn from billions of words. It sounds articulate and thoughtful, as if it knows you, but it doesn't.

Without context, AI gives you the same generic advice it would give anyone. "Have you considered journaling?" "It might help to talk to a therapist." "Remember to practice self-care." These aren't wrong, exactly, just useless. It's like asking a doctor for help without telling them where it hurts.

The previous six chapters asked you to look at yourself more closely than most people ever do. Right now all of that lives in your head, maybe in some scattered notes. Me.md puts everything you've uncovered into one document that you, and any AI system you hand it to, can read.

The Sections

The document has six sections: five that hold what you've uncovered, and a revision log that tracks how the document changes. If this feels like a lot, relax: each of the first five draws directly from a chapter you've already read, so you're organizing what you've found rather than starting from scratch.

```
$ tree ~/me.md

me.md
│
├── Where I Came From
│   Context that shaped who you are.
│
├── My Foundation
│   Your Five Pillars, the non-negotiables.
│
├── Where I Am Going
│   Directional narratives, not goals.
│
├── My Relationship with Gain and Loss
│   What you gained, what it cost.
│
├── What I Need From AI
│   How AI should interact with you.
│
└── Revision Log
    Track how this document evolves.
```

Section 1: Where I Came From

Your background, your formative experiences, and the patterns you recognized in the first two chapters: where you came from, what shaped you, where you are now. Skip the polished version you'd put on a resume or a dating profile and write the real one, including the parts you usually leave out.

Section 2: My Foundation

The current state of your Five Pillars: what's working, what keeps collapsing, where you started versus where you are now. Add your cascade patterns: which pillar drags the others down when it slips, and which one pulls them forward when it

improves.

Section 3: Where I Am Going

This is your Chapter Three and Five material: the goals that survived the Effortless Goals filter, if any did, the core desires you found when you kept asking "why?", and the seeds you created for your pillars and life domains. "I am becoming someone who..." for each area that matters to you.

Section 4: My Relationship with Gain and Loss

How do you relate to winning and losing? What did your Post-Achievement Audit reveal? What did your gains actually give you versus what you expected? What did loss teach you that success couldn't?

Section 5: What I Need From AI

This might be the most practically useful section. How do you want AI to talk to you? What should it push back on? What should it absolutely not do?

If you respond well to directness, say so. If motivational cheerleading makes you want to throw your phone, say that. If you need AI to flag when you're running old scripts, write it down. If there are areas where you want help and areas where you don't, make it explicit.

This section shapes every future conversation. Without it, you get the default. The default is designed to be safe and pleasant, which usually means fucking useless.

Section 6: Revision Log

Keep a revision log. Nobody's checking; the point is that the changes become a record of your own evolution. "March 2027: updated Section 3, old seed no longer resonates, replaced with one that reflects where I actually am." "June 2027: rewrote Section 1 after processing shutting down the company."

Most people won't maintain their me.md. They'll write a version,

feel satisfied, and let it gather dust, and that's okay. Even a single honest version, written once, is more self-knowledge than most people ever organize. It will still serve you when you paste it into a conversation two years from now, just not as well as one you've kept current.

How to Build It

Don't try to write the whole thing in one sitting; that's the same "overhaul everything at once" trap I warned about with the pillars. Start where the friction is lowest and let momentum build. For most people, that's Section 3, your goals and seeds.

Section 5 (what you need from AI) is worth spending real time on. Think about the frustrating interactions you've had with AI: what went wrong, what you wished it had done instead, which tone works for you and which doesn't. Be specific. "Don't be overly positive" is okay. "When I'm catastrophizing, call it out directly instead of validating the spiral" is better. Think of this section as instructions for a very capable but very new assistant who wants to help but doesn't know you yet.

The first version is a draft, incomplete and imperfect, and that's fine. A rough document with honest material is far more useful than a polished one full of what you think you should say. Nobody is grading it; the only measure of quality is honesty. If a section makes you cringe a little to write, you're probably doing it right. Leave sections blank if you're not ready. A gap is better than filler, and you can come back to it later.

Before You Share It With AI

Be aware that when you use a cloud AI service, your conversation is sent to servers controlled by that company. What happens next depends on their policies. Some providers store your conversations indefinitely. Some use them to train future models,

meaning your words become part of the system's learning material. Some allow employees to review conversations for quality and safety. Policies vary between providers, change over time, and are often buried in terms of service that nobody reads.

Also consider how these models were built in the first place. Most large language models were trained on enormous amounts of data scraped from the internet, much of it without the consent of the people who created it. This is documented and still being litigated, and it shows they are more than willing to steal.

That said, most of us pour deeply personal information into email services, messaging apps, and social media without a second thought. People confess secrets over Snapchat and send medical details through unencrypted email boxes with 12345 as their password. The document you've built deserves more care than that, but the point isn't to be more paranoid about AI than you are about everything else.

The alternative is a local AI model that runs entirely on your own machine, so nothing leaves your computer: no servers, no storage policies, no training data contributions, no third-party access. Models that run on a powerful laptop are already capable enough to work with your document in meaningful ways, and they're improving fast.

The tradeoff today is capability. The largest cloud models are generally more capable than those that run locally. That gap is closing, and for many conversations a local model is more than sufficient, but for some the extra capability might matter. You get to decide where that line is for you. I only share my full document on my own local machine, a technical luxury that I think is worthwhile for me.

At minimum, before you paste your document into any AI system, know the answers to these questions: Does this provider store my conversations? Can I delete them? Are they used for training? Can I opt out? If you can't find clear answers, assume

the worst.

How to Use It

The most immediate use is pasting it into the beginning of any AI conversation, whether career advice, emotional support, or decision-making. One practical note: don't always use the full document. The complete document is a lot of text, and flooding a conversation with too much context can actually degrade the quality of the output. Share the sections that are relevant to what you're working on. If you're making a career decision, the AI doesn't need your full health history.

Take a simple question: "I'm thinking about changing careers. What should I consider?"

Without your document, you get generic advice about researching industries and updating your resume. With your document, you get a response that knows your pattern of fusing identity with achievement, that knows your sleep collapses when you're stressed, that knows you're prone to chasing external validation when you feel insecure, and that knows your seed is "I am becoming someone who creates from genuine interest rather than proving worth." The advice that comes back from that foundation is a different species entirely.

Beyond AI conversations, the document works as a decision-making filter. When a choice comes up, pull up the document and ask: does this align with my seeds? Does this serve my actual desires or my inherited scripts? Does this strengthen my pillars or undermine them?

Share it with a therapist or coach if you have one. Most professionals spend the first several sessions trying to understand who you are. It's not a replacement for the relationship, but it's a hell of a starting point.

Use it with people you trust, not as a "here, read my life story"

but as a reference when you're making decisions together, working through problems, or trying to explain where you're coming from.

The document doesn't tell you what to do; it tells you who you are and where you're pointed. The decisions still require judgment, courage, and occasionally dumb luck. The document just makes sure you make them with your eyes open.

Working Section

me.md

This is where you draft your me.md. Each section below corresponds to a section of your document. Don't try to write it all in one sitting. Start where the friction is lowest.

Section 1: Where I Came From

Your background. Your formative experiences. The patterns you recognized in the first two chapters. Not the polished version, the real one.

Section 2: My Foundation

Each of the Five Pillars. Current state. What's working, what keeps collapsing. Your cascade patterns.

Section 3: Where I Am Going

Goals that survived the Effortless Goals filter, if any. Core desires. Your directional seeds.

Section 4: My Relationship with Gain and Loss

How do you relate to winning and losing? What did your Post-Achievement Audit reveal?

Section 5: What I Need From AI

How should AI talk to you? What should it push back on? What should it never do? Be specific.

Section 6: Revision Log

Track how this document evolves.

Chapter Eight: The Story Continues

If you were expecting a summary, you won't find one here. Seven chapters of arguing against finish lines, and then I hand you a tidy conclusion with bullet points? That would send you off with confidence.

But confidence is exactly what got us into this mess. The certainty that we know what we want, that the path is clear, and that arrival is possible.

Where I Am

Right now, I'm in the middle of my own shift. It's happening but not complete. I've stopped chasing the scoreboards that were handed to me. I've built my pillars, imperfectly, with frequent collapses and rebuilds. I've planted my seeds:

I am becoming someone who creates from genuine interest rather than proving worth.

I am becoming someone who holds success and failure with the same loose grip.

I am becoming someone who tends their pocket of order without burning themselves out.

Some days these feel true. Other days I catch myself reaching for the old games: the metrics, the comparisons, the desperate need to matter. The difference is I notice now. I can watch the craving arise without immediately obeying it.

The Invitation

Now take what's useful. Discard what isn't. Build your pillars. Plant your seeds. Fill your document. Hand it to any AI and the conversation changes; no more generic advice, no more starting from zero. Every future conversation begins from who you actually are.

Maybe we compare notes later. Maybe we discover that I was wrong.

What I do know is that chasing someone else's goals with someone else's timeline on someone else's scoreboard was making me miserable. Stopping that, even without knowing what comes next, was the right move.

The story continues.

"May I never be complete. May I never be content. May I never be perfect." Chuck Palahniuk, Fight Club (1996)

See you out there.

Kind regards,

Rudie Nolasco Verweij

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